

CASE STUDY – Airline Operational Crisis

Client: Northwind Air (fictional) Engagement: August 2025

SITUATION

A four-day operational failure grounded 340 flights. Media coverage moved from operational to governance within 36 hours, which is the transition that determines whether a crisis ends in an apology or a resignation.

WHAT WE DID

Stood up a single-channel escalation ladder with three named spokespeople and one approver. Rewrote the holding statement four times in the first eight hours as facts formed. Refused two interview requests that would have put an unbriefed executive on camera.

RESULT

Coverage returned to operational framing by day three. No governance-level departures.

WHAT WE WOULD DO DIFFERENTLY

The escalation ladder was built during the crisis. It should have existed before hand. Every retained client now gets one in the first 30 days as a standing deliverable.